

□ My Question □

जिज्ञासा : జిజ్ఞాస

A personal prologue to the reflections that follow

A note to the reader. *What follows is not directed at any contemporary conflict, group, or tradition. It is one person's attempt — after a long time of carrying the question — to articulate what one of humanity's oldest texts actually says, as distinct from what its modern translations sometimes make it say. I write as one fellow human trying to clear a window, not break one. If anything here causes offense, that offense is not the intent; the failure is mine, not the text's. Read with whatever softness you can spare.*

The verse that bothered me

"Better one's own dharma, however imperfect, than another's well performed." — BG 3.35, repeated again at 18.47

I first met this verse many years ago, in an English translation that rendered it as *"better your own religion than another's."* And I hated it. It sounded — to me, a young reader — like exactly the tribal counsel I was hoping a great text would not give: *stay in your tribe, do not cross over, the path you were born into is the one you must die in.* It seemed to confirm the smallness I was watching the world act out, not transcend it.

But I had a hunch — a quiet, decade-long hunch — that the translation was wrong. The text could not really be saying this. Not the same text whose opening word is *dharma-kṣetra* (the field of right action) and whose closing instruction is *"abandon all dharmas; take refuge in Me alone."* A text that says "abandon all dharmas" cannot, in the next breath, be telling anyone to defend one dharma against another.

So I began, slowly, to follow a thread. I read Gandhi. Gandhi led me to Tolstoy. Tolstoy led me back to the Upaniṣads and the Gītā. The Gītā led me to the Sanskrit. The Sanskrit led me to the discovery that **the word *dharma* does not mean "religion"** — and could not have meant it, because the very category of "religion" (as a system of beliefs that one belongs to in distinction from other systems) **did not yet exist anywhere in the world** when the Gītā was composed.

At that moment a great deal became clear at once. The verse I had hated was not the verse I had been reading. It said something quite different — and something far more useful. It said:

Be authentic to your own calling, however imperfectly. Do not imitate another's life. Do not fake another's path. Even an unsteady walk on your own road is worth more than a confident walk on someone else's.

No tribes. No religions. No defense of one identity against another. Only the quiet ancient counsel to be honestly oneself, and to do what only one can do.

The bigger question that opened

Once that single mistranslation came loose, a larger question came with it. If the Gītā is not about religion — what is it about? And why has it been read, again and again across centuries, by people of every culture, as if it were speaking directly to them?

The answer that slowly arrived was this:

The truth that the Gītā speaks of is not the property of any people, century, language, or geography. It is the same truth that — wherever it is heard, by whoever is listening — will speak itself again, in whatever idiom is available, through whoever happens to be ready.

The Gītā itself promises this, in BG 4.7:

यदा यदा हि धर्मस्य ग्लानिर्भवति भारत ।
अभ्युत्थानमधर्मस्य तदात्मानं सृजाम्यहम् ॥

yadā yadā hi dharmasya glānir bhavati bhārata |
abhyutthānam adharmasya tadātmānaṁ sṛjāmy aham ||

**"Whenever the upholding-truth weakens, and unrighteousness rises —
then I send forth Myself."**

This verse is usually read as a Hindu doctrine of divine incarnation: God descends, in a particular form, in particular ages, in a particular land. But it can also be read — and I think it must be read — as a description of **how truth actually behaves in history**. Whenever the inner law is forgotten somewhere, it speaks again somewhere. Not always in Sanskrit. Not always with a flute. Not always with skin of a certain color, or in robes of a certain cut. But always with the same message: *act without claiming, renounce by not clinging, see the One in all, surrender what you cannot control*.

That recognition — that this is one truth speaking through many mouths — is what I want, in the reflections that follow, to try to articulate.

The cycle — neither time nor continents separate it

Here, briefly, is the lineage I followed. The dates are approximate. The pattern is not.

APPROXIMATE DATE	VOICE	THE SAME TEACHING, IN THEIR LANGUAGE
~800–500 BCE	Īśā Upaniṣad	<i>tena tyaktena bhuñjīthāḥ</i> — "By renouncing, enjoy." Live in this world without grasping at it; that is how it is truly enjoyed.
~500–200 BCE	Bhagavad Gītā (2.47)	<i>karmaṇy evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana</i> — "You have the right to action; you have no right to its fruit." Act, fully — but do not own the outcome.
~500 BCE	The Buddha (Dhammapada 5)	<i>na hi verena verāni sammantīdha kudācanaṃ</i> — "Hatred is never appeased by hatred in this world. By non-hatred alone is it appeased. This is the eternal law."
~600 BCE	Lao Tzu (Tao Te Ching 8)	"The highest goodness is like water. Water benefits all things and does not contend." Act without contending; flow rather than fight.
~1st century CE	Jesus of Nazareth (Matthew 5:39, 44)	"Resist not him who is evil... love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you." The same renunciation of vengeance, in Aramaic.
~13th century	Jalāluddīn Rūmī (Persia)	"Out beyond ideas of wrong-doing and right-doing, there is a field. I will meet you there." The same field. The same recognition. Persian Sufi voice.
1908	Leo Tolstoy <i>A Letter to a Hindu</i>	"The teaching of all the wise men of all nations — Krishna, Buddha, Lao-Tse, Confucius, Isaiah, Christ, Mahomet — is one and the same: the law of love." A Russian Christian, in his last years, recognizing the single voice.
1929	Mohandas Gandhi <i>Anāsakti Yoga</i>	Three words for an entire life, drawn from the Īśā Upaniṣad: "Renounce and enjoy." He renounced his legal career, his property, his title — and lived the verse.
1963	Martin Luther King Jr. <i>Letter from Birmingham Jail</i>	"Returning hate for hate multiplies hate, adding deeper darkness to a night already devoid of stars... Only love can do that." Gandhi's method, in Atlanta English.
Continuing	The next voice	Not yet named. Not yet known. Speaking now, somewhere, in some language none of the previous voices used. <i>That is what yadā yadā means.</i>

Notice what this table does not say. It does not say that these voices were the same person, or that the teachings are interchangeable in every detail, or that the differences among them do not matter. They do. The differences are real, the cultures are real, the disagreements on specifics are real, and erasing them would be its own form of disrespect.

But it does say something quieter, and harder to deny: **the deepest counsel given by the wisest voices of the most disparate cultures, across 2,500 years and several continents, sounds suspiciously like one voice — passed from hand to hand, language to language, century to century, never quite identical, never quite different, never extinguished.**

This is not a religious claim. It is closer to an observation about how truth behaves. Truth, when it is the deepest kind, does not respect borders — neither of time, nor of continents, nor of the labels by which we sort ourselves.

What I hope these reflections are — and are not

These reflections are not a defense of any tradition. They are not an attack on any tradition. They are not a comparative-religion exercise, where the goal is to show that all religions are "really" the same (they are not, and they should not be). They are not aimed at any contemporary conflict, named or unnamed. They are not an opinion column. They are not propaganda.

They are an attempt — slow, careful, and humble — to recover a few words that the centuries have worn down: **dharma**, **sva-dharma**, **para-dharma**, **kṣetra**, **kṣetrājña**. And through them, to recognize the shape of a single teaching that the human race seems unable to stop forgetting, and that wisdom seems unable to stop offering again.

If they succeed at all, they will succeed not by persuading anyone of anything they did not already half-know — but by giving back, perhaps, a few words to readers who had been quietly avoiding them because of how they had been mistranslated.

That, I think, is the most a piece of writing of this kind can honestly aim for.

The overarching discipline

One last word about how these reflections are written. The Gītā itself, in 2.47, teaches the discipline called *anāsakti* — non-attachment to the fruit of action. I have tried, with mixed success, to compose in that spirit. **I am not attached to whether anyone reads these.** I am not attached to whether anyone agrees. I have done my part by writing as clearly and as honestly as I can. What happens after that is not my business; it is the business of whatever reader these words happen to reach, and of whatever larger pattern these words are a tiny part of.

If you have read this far, thank you. I owe you the same softness I asked of you at the top of the page. May whatever you read here clear a window, and never break one.

— the writer, with humility and gratitude.

□ **The three reflections that follow**

1. **What Dharma Is Not** · the historical and linguistic recovery — why *dharma* ≠ "religion," and why the difference matters.
2. **The Mountain Has Many Paths** · the Gītā's own stance toward different ways — drawn entirely from its own verses (4.11, 7.20–23, 9.23, 17.3, 18.66).
3. **Yadā Yadā — The Eternal Recurrence of Dharma** · the lineage above, set out at length, with the actual texts in parallel — and a closing meditation on what it might mean for the present.